A PERSONAL INTEREST. A RELEASED PRODUCT.

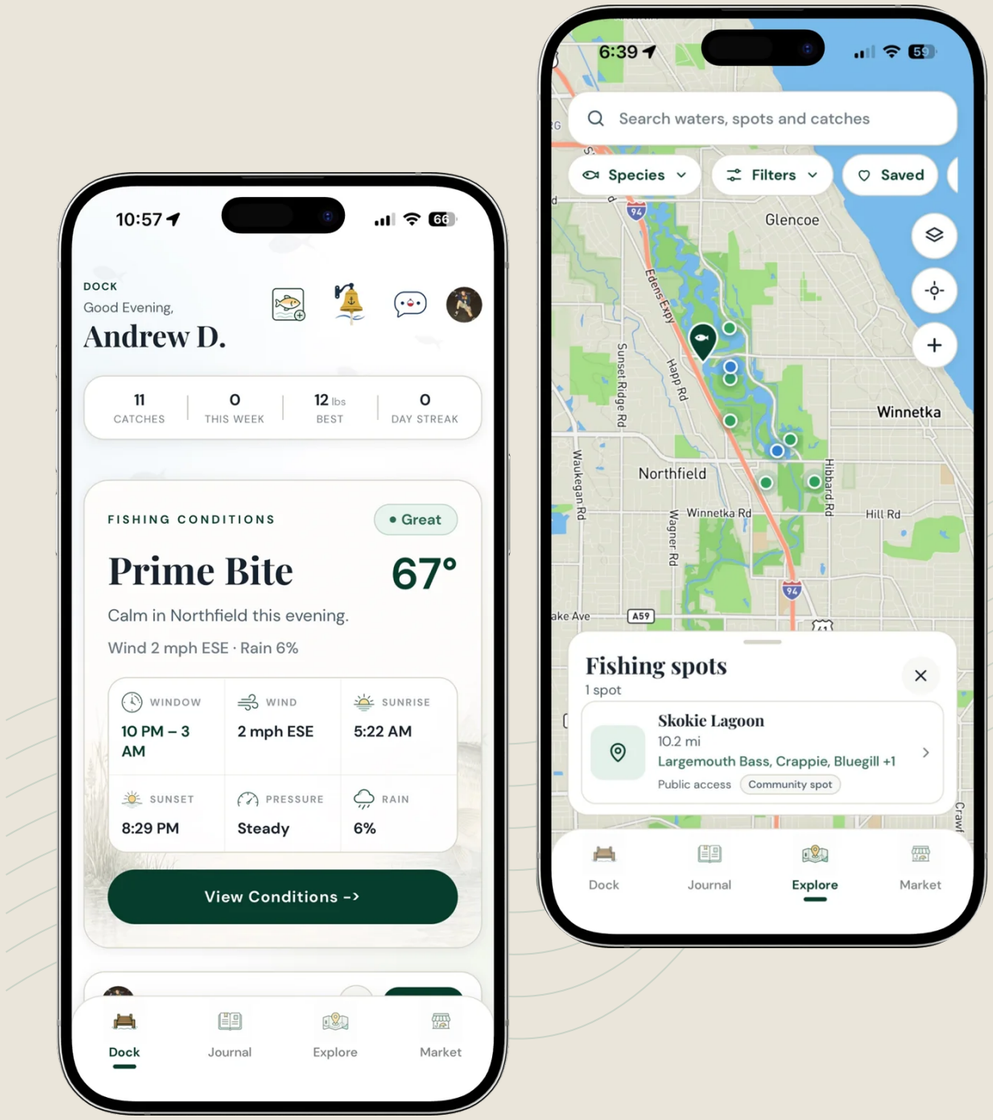
Backwater Journal

Every catch has a story.

An independent iOS app I shaped, designed, built and released. It connects trip preparation, catch records, nearby discovery and an angler community.

MY ROLE

Founder, product designer and mobile app developer



CURRENT WEBSITE PRODUCT-TOUR SCREENS

FROM FISHING INTEREST TO PRODUCT

I took the idea beyond the mockup.

Fishing gave me a reason to build something of my own. Backwater Journal brings a trip together: checking conditions before going out, recording catches, finding places nearby and sharing with other anglers.

01

Product direction

I shaped the experience around logging, discovery, community and fishing gear.

02

Interface + implementation

I took the design through to a working mobile app rather than stopping at static screens.

03

Release + refinement

The product was released on the App Store and has continued through a documented update.

PLATFORM

iOS / iPhone

INITIAL RELEASE

July 14, 2026

VERIFIED UPDATE

1.1.0 / September 27, 2026

AVAILABLE REGIONS

United States and Canada

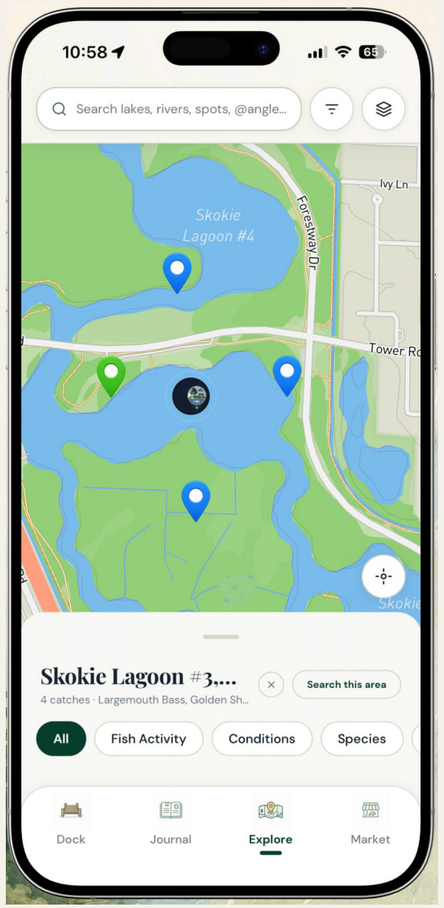
TOOLS

Figma, React Native / Expo, Supabase, TestFlight

An independent product available on the App Store.

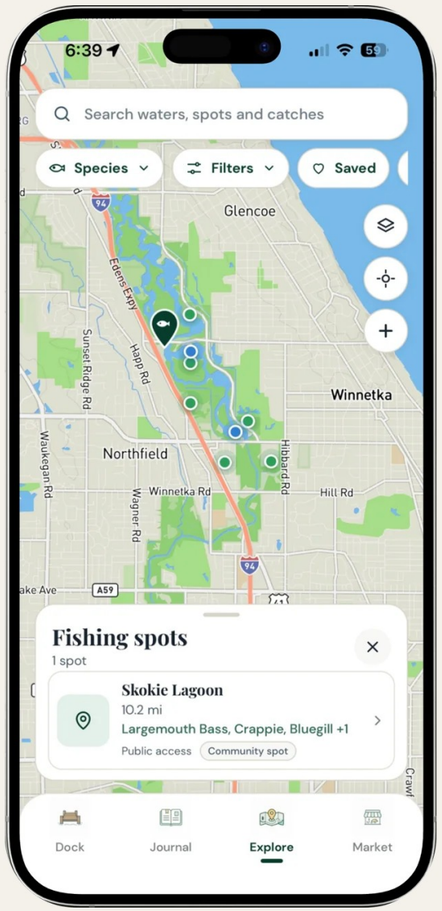
BEFORE AND AFTER 1.1.0

What changed in Explore.



EARLIER EXPLORE

Cropped from the earlier App Store screenshot, added to this portfolio on July 7, 2026, before the 1.1.0 update.



CURRENT EXPLORE

The current website product-tour screen, matching the App Store screenshot after 1.1.0.

01 ## Search scope

The search field changed from “Search lakes, rivers, spots, @angle…” to “Search waters, spots and catches”.

02 ## Filters

Icon-only buttons beside search, plus a row of chips at the bottom (All, Fish Activity, Conditions, Species and more), became labelled Species, Filters and Saved chips directly under search.

03 ## Selected spot

The bottom sheet became a compact Fishing spots panel listing distance, species and access labels.

DOCUMENTED REASON

> “Explore has been rebuilt with improved fishing spot discovery, catch activity, saved fishing spots, weather and fishing conditions, and better map interactions.”

Version 1.1.0 release notes, App Store

A July 2026 development audit documented the earlier Explore controls. With the rebuild, I wanted the main ways to narrow the map in one place, under search, named rather than shown as icons. No user feedback is documented for this change, and it is untested with people.

ONE PRODUCT, SEVERAL CONNECTED JOBS

Keep the fishing experience connected.

The design intent is to connect the moments before, during and after a trip without making every task feel the same.

01

Prepare

Dock + Explore

Conditions and nearby discovery.

02

Record

Catch Log + Journal

Structured records and personal stories.

03

Revisit

Species + catch history

A record that becomes useful over time.

04

Connect

Community + Market

Share experiences and coordinate gear trades.

TWO KINDS OF RECORDS

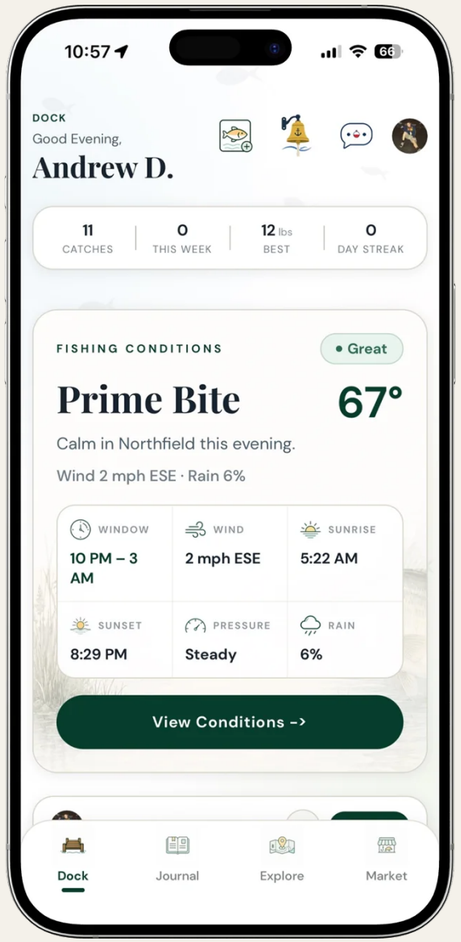
A catch log captures a single fish with structured details. A journal entry holds the notes, stories and updates that do not fit into those fields.

DESIGN PRINCIPLE

Keep structure where it helps people remember details; leave room for expression where the experience is personal.

PLANNING AND SHARING HAVE DIFFERENT JOBS

A useful starting point. A place to connect.



DOCK / CONDITIONS



DOCK / SHARED CATCH

01

Conditions at a glance

Dock brings the bite window, weather details and catch statistics into one opening view.

02

Catches become stories

The community experience pairs a shared catch with a photograph and key fishing details.

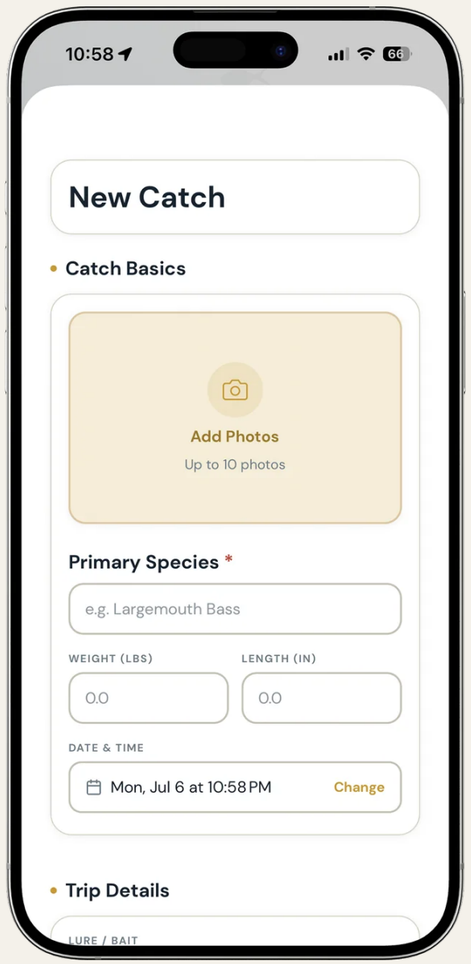
03

Keep the purpose clear

My design intent is to let practical information support the trip while community content adds a reason to return.

THE DETAILS WORTH REMEMBERING

Turn a catch into a useful record.



A STRUCTURED CAPTURE FLOW

The catch form supports photos, species, weight, length, date and time, alongside bait or lure and trip details. Photos and fields serve different purposes: the image remembers the moment, while the data supports later review.

01

Start with the catch

The visible form groups photographs and core facts before the trip details.

02

Support interrupted use

Version 1.1.0 added offline drafts, so recording work can be kept when connectivity is limited.

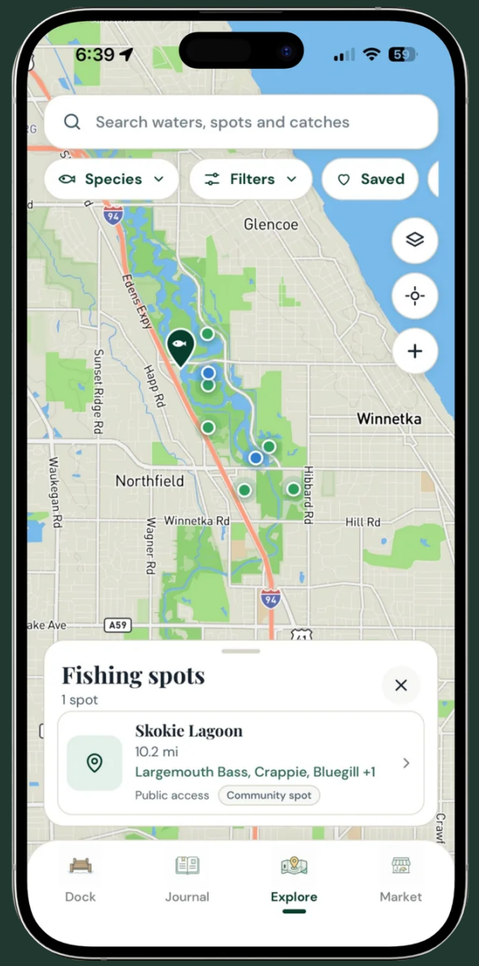
03

Keep history portable

The same release added catch-history export and measurement improvements.

THE MAP AS THE MAIN WORKSPACE

Make discovery easier to act on.



The current Explore screen leads with the map, then places search, species filters and saved access above it. A spot summary keeps the selected place connected to the map.

01

Search stays close

The search field names waters, spots and catches, making its scope visible.

02

The selected spot has context

A compact details panel sits above the bottom navigation rather than replacing the whole map.

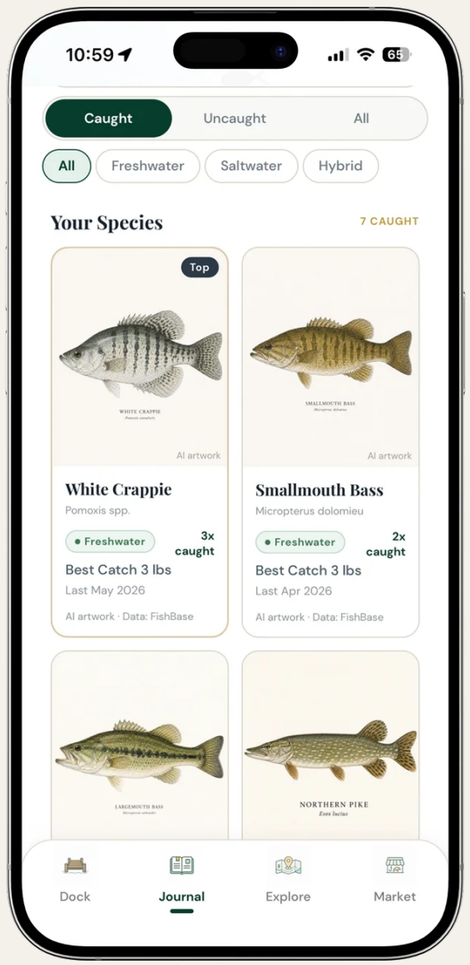
03

Filters sit under search

Species, Filters and Saved sit directly beneath search as labelled chips, with map controls on the right edge.

GIVE THE RECORD A REASON TO GROW

From individual catches to a personal collection.



A different view of the same history

The species collection shows caught fish with catch counts and best catches. Filters separate caught and uncaught species and different water types.

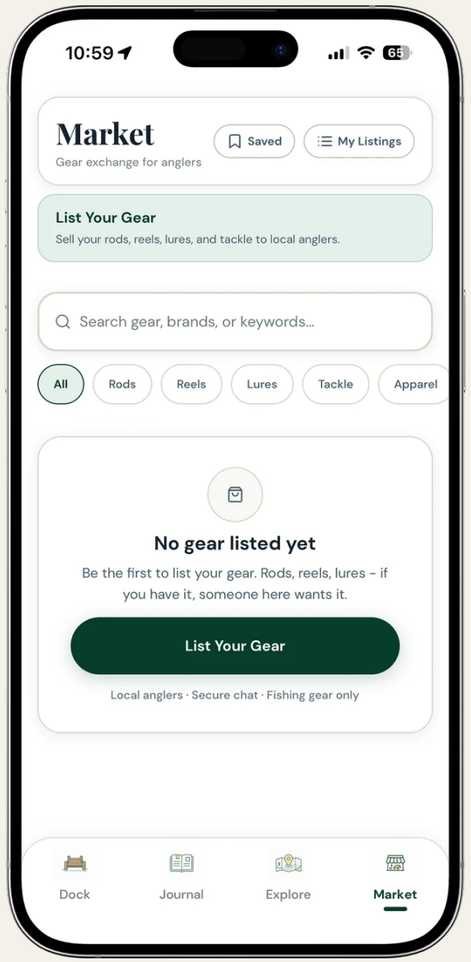
DESIGN INTENT

I want the journal to become more useful with each trip. A species view gives people another way to revisit their records without scrolling through every individual catch.

The counts visible in these screenshots belong to an example account. They are not evidence of app adoption or product performance.

A MARKETPLACE WITH CLEAR BOUNDARIES

Help people coordinate. State what the app handles.



Market supports gear search, categories, saved listings and creating a listing. Buyers and sellers message each other to arrange the transaction.

PRODUCT BOUNDARY

Backwater Journal does not process marketplace payments or provide buyer protection.

01

An empty state with a next step

The current screenshot shows no gear listed and offers a clear action to list gear. It does not imply a populated marketplace.

A PRODUCT THAT CONTINUED AFTER LAUNCH

The latest verified update changed the experience.

JULY 14, 2026

Initial release / 1.0

The App Store version history records the first public release.

SEPTEMBER 27, 2026

Refinement / 1.1.0

Explore was rebuilt, with additions to catch capture, portability and reliability.

01

Explore

Discovery, saved places, catch activity and map interactions.

02

Capture

Pin on Map, offline drafts and measurement improvements.

03

Ownership

Catch-history export.

04

Reliability

Privacy, performance and reliability improvements.

These are documented release changes. They do not establish improved task completion, retention or user satisfaction.

A FIELD-JOURNAL FEEL

Warm surfaces. Clear hierarchy. Room for the catch.

PRESENTATION PALETTE

Paper	Forest	Brass	Ink
#F4F1EA	#20382F	#D9A441	#1F2A24

Typography sets the pace.

Editorial serif headings bring character to this presentation. A quiet sans-serif keeps decisions, captions and product facts easy to scan.

MY PRESENTATION APPROACH

Large phone showcases, generous margins and subtle contour lines echo time on the water. Forest green anchors important sections; brass stays a restrained accent.

The palette is drawn from the current marketing site. Presentation typography is not a specification of every font used inside the app.

THE TRADEOFF I DESIGNED AROUND

Useful to others. Careful with places.

01

The tension

Shared catches make Explore more useful by showing what is being caught nearby. But the privacy policy warns that sharing exact catch locations can be sensitive.

02

Map sharing, as built

Checked against the 1.1.0 source, not the App Store build: a catch appears on the Explore map only if it is Public and its angler turns on Show on Explore map, which starts off. The map then shows it rounded to about 1 km.

03

What still needs evidence

Photo metadata and place labels can point to a spot too. My source changes for both since 1.1.0 are not in a verified release and do not alter photos already uploaded. I also want to test what people think a shared post reveals.

04

Controls and support

Published support describes reporting and blocking for listings, messages and accounts, and a path for privacy and deletion requests.

Proposed evaluation: log a catch, find and save a spot, explain what a shared post reveals, and create a listing. No usability testing has been done yet.

FROM IDEA TO AN ONGOING PRODUCT

Shipping the app was a beginning.

I took Backwater Journal from an idea to a released iOS app, then rebuilt Explore and strengthened catch logging in 1.1.0.

Explore taught me the most. The earlier screen split its filters between unlabelled icons at the top and chips at the bottom. Gathering them under search, with plain names, showed me that clarity often comes from placing a choice beside what it changes. Testing that with people, starting with the proposed evaluation tasks, comes next.

Name the choices.
Then test them with people.

SOURCE RECORD / OCT 14, 2026

Current product descriptions and screen assets

https://www.backwaterjournal.com/

App Store release history: 1.0 and 1.1.0

https://apps.apple.com/us/app/backwater-journal/id6761636518

Published privacy and support information

https://www.backwaterjournal.com/privacy/

https://www.backwaterjournal.com/support/

Public sources verify the released product. Design intent and next steps are presented separately from measured outcomes.